

Iron Age The historical period characterized by the use of iron for making weapons and tools.

medieval period Also known as the Middle Ages, the period in European history that lasted from about the 5th to the late 15th centuries CE.

Mesopotamia The region of modern-day Iraq lying between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers, where many of the earliest civilizations began.

metallurgy The study of metals and their uses.

metalworking The process of creating or shaping things out of metal.

missionary A religious person who seeks out and persuades others to adopt their religion.

monarchy A type of government in which a king or queen is recognized as the head of state, whether or not they hold real power.

nation An independent country, or a group of people who share historical or cultural ties.

nationalism Loyalty and devotion to a nation, and the political belief that its interests should be pursued as the primary goal of a political policy.

Neolithic Age The later Stone Age, during which improved stone tools and weapons were made and the first farming began.

nomadic Describing people who move from place to place without establishing a permanent settlement.

pandemic A sudden and widespread outbreak of disease.

peasant A worker on the land, usually an agricultural laborer.

persecute To oppress or harass a person or group because of their origins or beliefs.

philosophy A set of ideas or beliefs.

plantation A large area of fertile land within a landowner's estate where a certain type of crop is grown.

pre-Columbian The time period before the arrival of Christopher Columbus in the Americas.

republic A country without a monarch or emperor. Modern republics are usually led by presidents.

revolution A sudden and fundamental change in society brought about by an organized group of protesters. Can also be used to mean a major change in the way that people do things or think about things.

samurai A Japanese warrior who owes allegiance to a *daimyo* (a landowning noble) and follows a strict code of honor.

script The written characters that make up a writing system, such as an alphabet.

serf A peasant who is obligated to undertake agricultural work on their lord's land.

siege To surround a city or fortress with the intention of capturing it.

Silk Road An ancient trade route that extended from eastern China to the Mediterranean Sea.

socialism The belief that the government should have some control over the economy and be able to spread wealth more evenly among the people.

species A group of organisms that are similar to, and can breed with, each other.

state A country—or a region within a country—and its people. A state is ruled by a government.

suffrage The right to vote.

superpower A country with great political and military power, capable of influencing international politics.

terra-cotta A reddish-brown clay that is used for making pottery, sculptures, or ornaments.

treaty An official, written agreement between warring parties to bring hostilities to an end.

urbanization The large-scale movement of people from rural areas to urban areas such as towns and cities.

USSR The Union of Soviet Socialist Republics, the communist state that existed from 1922–1991 in the former Russian Empire, with its capital in Moscow.

West, the Europe and North America, or their ideals and culture when seen in contrast to other civilizations.

woodblock printing The process of using carved blocks of wood for printing on cloth or paper. This technique originated in China and was widely used across East Asia.